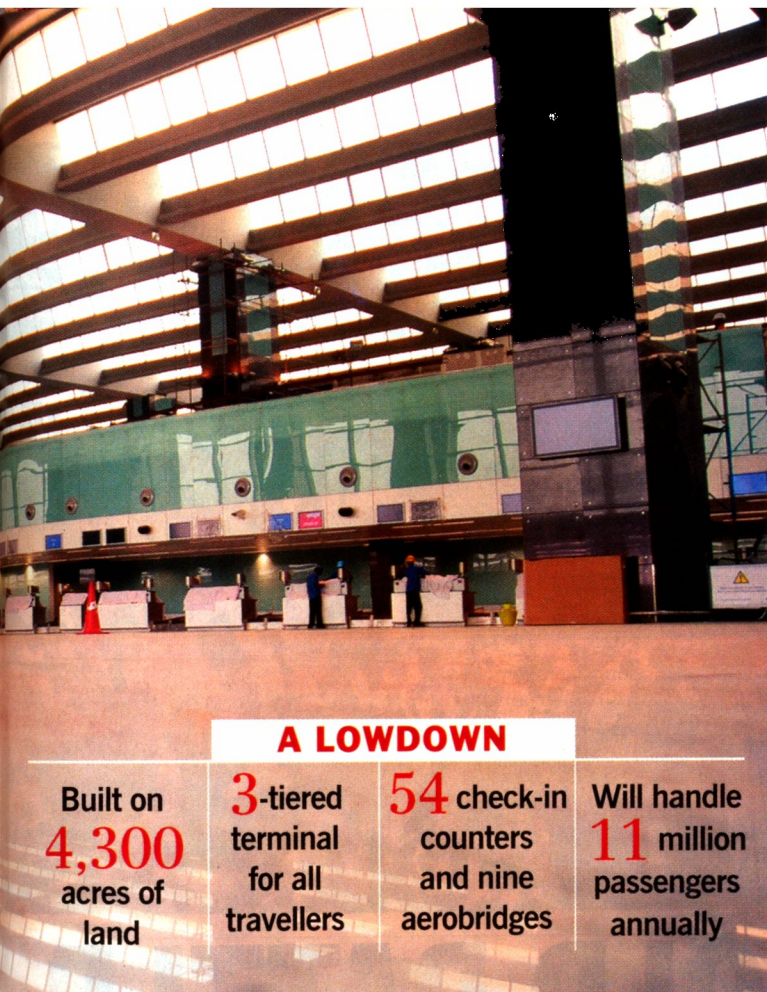




A LOWDOWN

Built on
4,300
acres of
land

3-tiered
terminal
for all
travellers

54 check-in
counters
and nine
aerobridges

Will handle
11 million
passengers
annually

THE AIRPOCKET

- ➔ A user development fee of Rs **675** for domestic and Rs **955** for international travellers plus taxes makes it the most expensive airport though the fee has been reduced till May 31
- ➔ Despite a **26%** stake held by state promoters, BIAL will not be open to public scrutiny because it is a private company
- ➔ Access roads and flyovers are still being constructed while the high speed direct train link from the city will take **3** years
- ➔ The projected passenger traffic could double from the current 11 million to 23 million by **2013** stretching capacity

NO WAITING, NO JOSTLING: Many check-in counters at the airport will cut down the queues

and writing instruments from Ethos, while the domestic departure area will have Carbon jewellery, LaModa fashion apparel, Odyssey Books, Shopper's Stop and Nuance. In keeping with its aspirations to compete with international airports, there will be a range of duty-free stores stacking tobacco, liquor, cosmetics, perfumes, souvenirs and even art. Refreshments will be provided by Kingfisher at their sports bar, Pizza Hut, ITC Kitchens and Illy Café from Paris. Barista, Café Coffee Day and HMSHost from The Netherlands will also have a presence in the terminal building. The waiting lounges will be run by Oberoi Hotels, Kingfisher Airlines and Jet Airways.

Users may not exactly be smiling, thanks to the proposed user development fee for passengers taking a flight out of Bangalore, lack of access roads and rail link and the increased cost and time involved in commuting. BIAL has ensured that there will be a fleet of 40 AC Volvo buses and 116 non-AC buses, besides 900 taxis to ferry passengers. Choppers by Deccan Aviation will connect the new airport to the city at a cost of \$100 (Rs 4,000) per person. The overall picture is not very rosy with a fall in the bookings of short haul flights by 30 per cent as confirmed by low-cost carriers. On top of this, the passenger traffic, which crossed 10 million in January 2008, and could touch 23 million by 2013, shows that air traffic growth predictions were wrong. With only one runway, the airport will need to have another one ready sooner rather than later. But, with Civil Aviation Minister Praful Patel planning 500 airports in the next five years, and with civil aviation looking to attract \$150 billion (Rs 6 lakh crore) worth of foreign investment, BIAL will most probably showcase the future of Indian aviation. ■

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